In The Shadow of Babala

BY JOHN MARLOWE



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(The road is)…one of the most breathtaking drives in Greece…You enter what looks like a short, narrow, very high gorge, only to discover when the right hand side of it drops away to reveal the sea below that however high the cliff above you to the left, there is a suddenly about twice as much of it again below you to the right. The ensuing descent into Kyparissi hits every superlative, with wonderful views to islands offshore, a fort above, chapels built into the rock, a road that shaves the vast red cliffs so tightly that needles of rock are left between you and the abyss, and then greenery, some magnificent trees and then Vrissi, the first and most beautiful of the three villages (of Kyparissi).

—The Most Beautiful Villages of Greece by Mark Ottaway

Vasilli Vasilliou is one lucky cabinetmaker in Kyparissi, Lakonias, Hellas, just like his cabinetmaker father, and his father's father, and his father's father's father, back for at least 200 years.

Standing outside his new shop on a spring morning, the sun warm on our backs, looking up at the timeless grey and gold Parnonas Mountains on one side and the flat purple Myrtou Sea on the other, I ask if he ever wishes he had stayed in the United States to work and make his fortune. He answers with his signature laugh. "Never. I come out of my shop, I look up at Babala the mountain, I look out to the sea. I fish. I work. I have a new shop with the best equipment. More work than I can do. I raise my animals and my bees. Who would want to be in another place?"

Kyparissi has experienced an economic boom in recent years, as diaspora return with money from work abroad; they all want new windows, larger doors, smoother floors, and kitchen cabinets. Vasilli is the go-to man. He makes the latest-style counters and cabinets for the new and remodeled homes in town, and he and his son Yorgos travel into the west, north, and south for similar work. He fits two-hundred-year-old doorways with carefully crafted local wood that is older than the village. He also makes, for his pleasure, hand carvings for traditional furniture and special doors. And he patiently lends tools, or does quick "freebies," helping with jammed shutters, a flat tire, a crucial telephone call that must be translated. Not to

mention helping his wife, Sophia, raise two daughters and a son.

As if life isn't good enough outside his shop, inside it is great. In a village that is not as big as an LA shopping mall, he has a state-of-the-art shop, equipped with all the latest German and Italian machinery, from a Holz-Her edgebander to a Casadei wide-belt sander to a Rafael panel saw.

Yet this most modern of shops floats in family history. Sitting atop an old hewn-oak workbench made by Vasilli's father, Yorgos, when he was a young man, are the planes his great, great grandfather used when he worked on the Suez Canal in the mid-1880s. His father's old bandsaw, which sits in the middle of the shop, looks like it was God's own saw, and like everything else, it has a story. Greek-made, it was loaded onto a caique in Pireus and strapped to the mast for its journey to Kyparissi. The boat left the harbor loaded with the huge saw, along with boxes of staples (macaroni, coffee, rice, etc.), as well as a few passengers, including one Kyparissioti who had just finished two years of work in the States. He had a briefcase full of his earnings in real paper money. Between the island of Spetsai and the mainland village of Kyparissi, bad weather hit, and they were in real danger of sinking. They tried to untie the saw from the mast and toss it overboard, but it was too heavy to move, so they threw everything else over—the macaroni, rice, coffee…and the guy's briefcase.

A picture of the Virgin Marie and another of Aghios Pandeleimon, the saint whose job it is to protect good people from accidents, are now on the saw; the picture was not in place in time to save the briefcase. In many Greek carpenter, boatbuilder, and cabinetmakers' shops, you will find the same pictures of Pandeleimon, as well as Joseph, the father of Jesus, who, though not a saint, was, more importantly in this context, a carpenter.

Vasilli cannot work without tripping over all this history. We need history, geography, and, of course, mythology to establish him in time and place.

At her narrowest point, the Corinth Canal cuts Greece into roughly 2/3 and 1/3. Her lower third is called the Peloponnessos, and Kyparissi sits on the sea in the most southern portion of the Peloponnessos, in the province of Lakonias. The Parnonas Mountains stretch wildly and proudly on this side of Greece that more or less faces Turkey, dropping in plumb-line-straight cliffs into the Myrtou Sea, forming a natural, magnificent, monumental fortress wall with few harbors and fewer villages. The sea washes against high perpendicular cliffs so steeply a fisherman must sail miles north or south to find a bay in which to rest. This isolation gives the village an island culture, even though it is on the mainland. Kyparissi is on few modern maps; it doesn't have a tee-shirt for tourists; it barely has tourists.

At the small bay and atypical beaches of Kyparissi, the earth uncharacteristically slopes up for about a mile-and-a-half of fertile land, in an alluvial delta covered with settled soil and dust that has been tossed and carried by the wind for millions of years. It steps up in terraced olive groves to the base of Babala Mountain, a 2,500 feet high mighty prow of a dignified, timeless feat of nature.

A spring and some three or four shallow caves sit at the base of Babala, a little above where perpendicular stone meets fertile, sloping soil. Legend has it that the Amazon goddess Artemis created an eternally beautiful spot in this rugged, rocky terrain when her sacred deer was thirsty with no fresh water in sight, so she struck the cliff with a stone, creating a hole from which sterling ice cold water burst forth. These days a steep hike past an old mill, under its crumbling aqueducts, through a fern-covered breach full of song birds





ALL PHOTOS BY JAMIE LEVIEUX EXCEPT AS NOTED



OPPOSITE PAGE—
The village of Kyparissi, Greece, a secluded port tucked up against Babala Mountain, is the home of furniture and cabinetmaker Vasilli Vasilliou.

THIS PAGE, CLOCKWISE FROM RIGHT—
Vasilli Vasilliou, standing outside his woodshop, tends to his fishing nets.

Sitting atop an old oak workbench built by Vasilli's father are some of the hand planes his great great grandfather used in the trade.

Affixed to the old bandsaw that sits in the center of his shop are pictures of the Virgin Mary and Saint Pandeleimon, protector against accidents.

and floating patches of multi-colored butterflies, up through a fissure in the cliff wall, will bring you to the same pure, thick ancient water pouring from the same hole in the same rock in the same place, two thousands years later.

Artemis and you are not the only important travelers to walk in the shadow of Babala. In 200 AD, the Roman traveler/writer Pausanias walked Greece, writing of all he saw, and he noted the baths at Kyparissi. These baths, like the spring, are still in place in the shallow caves above the village. They feature carved niches for icons and candles, carved tubs and comfortable smooth floors hewn level by human hand. These baths are just there, out in the open, no fence, no gate, no ticket-taker, no tickets to take, no brochure, just an ancient site that is as much a part of the daily life of Kyparissi and Vasilli Vasilliou as the sun, the sea, and his morning coffee at Revatso's.

Vasilli Vasilliou, like his father Yorgos Vasilliou before him, and Yorgos's father before him, and *his* father…—back into the early 1800s—does excellent, utilitarian and, when time allows, inspired woodwork in the same place his immediate ancestors shaped wood, and earlier ancestors shaped civilization; at the very spot his great great great great grandfather courted his great great great great grandmother.

In the early 1800s, the original Vasilli Vasilliou sailed from the island of Karpathos, which sits between Rhodes and Crete, to Kyparissi in search of boat-building wood: oaks for planking for their caiques, the graceful/clunky nautical trucks of the Aegean, as well as a hard, golden wood, called *tsirmideli* in Greek, used for nails or pegs. They cut the trees, dragged them down the hills, loaded them onto their boats, and sailed back to Karpathos.

As beautiful as caiques are, and as skillful as builders like Vasilliou were, there was a down side to their work. They made damn fine boats, but they laid bare the islands and mainland. The ecological sins of the fathers now visit the sons. For example, the first island to the north, Spetsai, used to be called Pityousa or Pine Island, until all the pines were cut for boats. Clearcutting in Greece was exacerbated by the fact that grazing goats and sheep would eat anything green, so new shoots didn't have a ghost of a chance.

These days, wood comes in by foreign boats from foreign lands. Now, as a general rule, what Greek wood there is is best for the fireplace. It is soft and prone to termites and rot, so good wood has to be imported from Europe, the States, and Africa.

While unwittingly decimating the greenery, Vasilliou The Older and his crew visited and stayed with the miller at Artemis's spring. Vasilliou, as any good storyteller would have it, fell in love with the miller's daughter. They married, raised seven sons and one daughter. The oldest son built a house down by the beach, the first one in the modern, existing village. The second brother built next door uphill, and so on, creating a row of beautiful rectangular stone houses that, by law and by aesthetics, are annually painted with *asvestis* (white wash), creating layer upon glowing layer as thick as mayonnaise, topped by red roof tiles and decorated with traditional blue windows and doors. Blue is the proper color of all exterior wood on Greek houses by the sea.

Vasilliou The Older and his sons built and repaired boats, and as the tree supply dwindled along with their wanderlust, they shifted into carpentry and all jobs vaguely requiring woodworking skills. Ironically, contemporary Vasilliou's least favorite job is to work on boats, because "I have learned to make everything square. Nothing is square on a boat."

Vasilli Vasilliou continues the family work, as the side of his truck says: *paradosiakey*, roughly translated "traditional cabinetry." Or as Vasilliou explained, "You know, this guy teaches that guy."

To some, this might be a better story if Vasilli was an artist with esoteric skills (he has some), or if he used only ancient tools (he has some but he is moving to computerized German and Italian machines as fast as he and the European Economic Council can afford it), or if he created furniture in traditional styles (he does often replicate island and Byzantine furniture).

But the simple, wonderful truth is that Vasilli Vasilliou's art is his life. He loves and respects his family, past, present, and future. He lives in one of the most beautiful places on earth. He does good work, makes a good living, and he is proud of it. He works in a family tradition that goes back over two hundred years in the same place, and just like everything and everybody in Greece, he has a complex, entertaining, and instructive story. Everybody is Zorba, and you can't buy a loaf of bread without getting into the last century, or hearing music float in the crisp green auras of ancient grey olive trees. Even the goats make music with their bells as they walk.



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Kyparissi has three sections: furthest uphill toward the mountains is Vrissi ("spring"); then, spread along the gentle slopes is Metropoli, the newest part of town; at water's edge is Paralia ("beach"), pictured above.









PHOTO COURTESY OF VASILLI VASILLIOU

CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT—
Inside the shop is a mix of old and new, from ancient handtools to the latest German and Italian machinery; a Holz-Her edgebander stands to the right in the foreground.

Hanging on the wall are some of the handtools passed along to Vasilli from his father Yorgos.

The work made in the shop reflects the diverse and eclectic needs of the surrounding communities, from contemporary cabinets to traditional local furniture, as seen in this picture.

Vasilli runs some door panels through his Casadei Libra 2 wide-belt sander.

Vasilli Vasilliou's contemporary history started in 1969, when he was 16. Yorgos Vasilliou, his father, took him to the United States, leaving his wife, younger son, and daughter behind. The village was still poor. The ravages to the Greek economy by World War II and the following brutal Civil War were still a part of life almost twenty years after the fact. Electricity and roads were known, but not in evidence in Kyparissi until fifteen years after the family emigrated. Like most Greeks, Yorgos Vasilliou had an uncle who "skipped" ship and worked in San Francisco; he was their contact.

Regularly, before and after the war, men sailed on merchant ships and jumped them in foreign ports like New York, San Francisco, Sydney, and Montreal. The diaspora formed Greek communities with homes in foreign lands and hearts in Hellas. The fortunes of the hard-working diaspora grew, but they did not forget where they came from. They sent money back to their villages for better city streets, improved water systems, and, most important, improved schools.

They worked in the fields, as busboys in restaurants, produce clerks in super markets, and their offsprings became doctors, teachers, actors, lawyers, and politicians.

In 1972, having established a base, Yorgos returned to Greece and brought

the rest of the family with him to San Francisco. Vasilli went to Samuel Gompers High in the city, and then transferred to John O'Connell Vocational High School to learn more about modern cabinetry. His father worked at Coliseum Cabinet Works in Oakland, and Vasilli later worked there too.

In 1976, Vasilli went back to Greece to work on a house in Piraeus, between Athens and the sea, and, naturally, he also visited Kyparissi and met, fell in love with, and married Sophia, now the mother of his son and two daughters. She was then, and is now, one of the most beautiful women in the village. After their marriage, they returned to San Francisco and she went to Newcomer High to learn English, and they had their first child in 1979—Yorgos, named, as is the custom, after his grandfather.

This custom of naming Greek men after their grandfathers creates a lot of confusion: because they are saints' names, and because there are a limited number of saints, a lot of the kids have the same names. Having a village full of Vasillis and Yorgoses is not uncommon. To simplify things, a system of nicknames has evolved. Nicknames don't skip a generation like proper names. One guy is nicknamed "Wire" because his grandfather once received a telegram, and the nickname is passed on, father to son. Another guy is named Monumos which means "stays in one place." When he was a baby, his mother would bundle him up, tell him to stay under a tree when she took off to tend the goats; he would stay where she told him. His son is also called Monumos, and so will his son. It will not matter even if he has wandering feet. Vasilli's father's nickname was Rozos ("knot hole"), because he worked with wood. Vasilli is always called Rozos by his friends.

After Yorgos's birth, Vasilli returned to work at his family's trade in the very shop built by his great great grandfather, a building more beautiful than functional. It had wonderful arched ceilings but not much room to work on long boards. They had to open doors and windows for the big work, and sometimes drag the big equipment outside. Wood was delivered by caique, not truck as it is today.

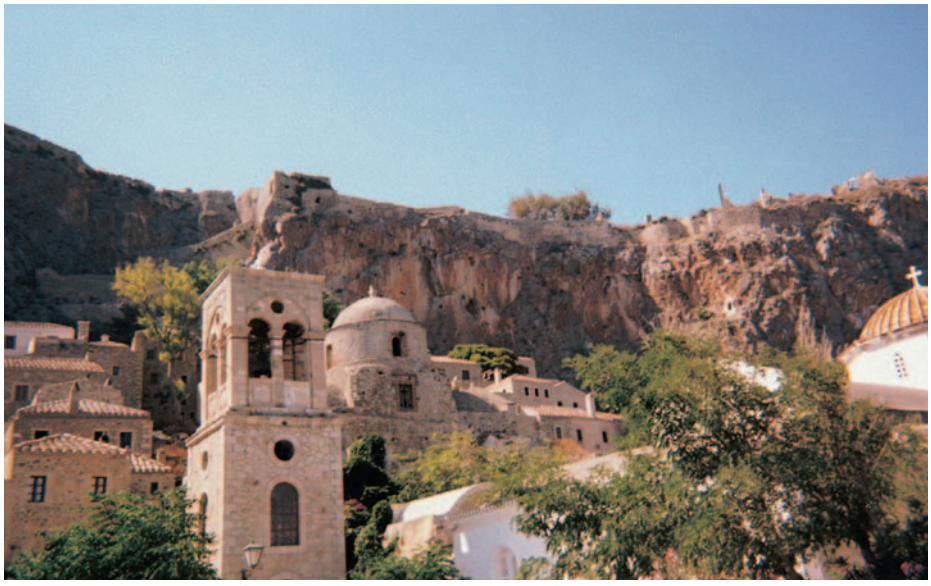


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Vasilli and his son Yorgos do business in most of the neighboring towns as well. Pictured above is Monovassia, about a 1-1/2 hour drive south of Kyparissi, where they have worked on many restorations.

Up until fairly recently, everything they made was small and functional. There was no demand for large projects—everyone was his own handyman, and the village was pretty much self-sufficient. The 80s brought in new money. The diaspora returned. The 90s added the European Economic Council (EEC), with a hefty checkbook to help local projects. American-, Canadian- and Australian-Greeks, keeping true to their roots, returned and rebuilt the old houses, enlarged the doors, replaced the roofs, put in new floors, cleared and expanded basements that were stalls for donkeys and pens for chickens, making them into bedrooms and inside toilets. They all needed windows, doors, closets, stairs, and cabinets made by someone with the skill of Yorgos and Vasilli Vasilliou.

The new single lane road over the mountains is a major factor in the prosperity of the village and the Vasilliou family. The road is about 20 years old, not even a blink of an eye in Greek history, and it has been paved for about the last eight. The road is so narrow through the village that corners have been lopped off the houses so the trucks and the daily bus can make it around the corners. Now, from Easter to the fall, Kyparissi hums with cicadas and Beemers of returning Kyparissiotis who traveled and relocated abroad, but kept strong ties with their village. Soon Vasilli and his father had more work than they and their shop could handle. And Yorgos wasn't getting any younger.

With all of this progress, it was time for a new, larger, modern operation. The original shop was fine for handwork, but as machines grew in number and size, the shop was more cramped than quaint. Vasilliou chose a site above the dry creek on the north edge of town. Above this dry creek now stands Vasilli's 40 meters square shop, new since 1992. It has a full stock of modern equipment, most of which his father would not recognize, let alone know how to work. Vasilli confesses that sometimes he has to ask his son Yorgos to work the equipment. "My son knows better how to work the German and Italian machines." He ought to. Like his father, Yorgos added formal education to family experience by spending two years in an Athenian cabinetry school, *Diplarios Iiek*, part of a network of private Italian, Spanish, and Greek technical trade schools. He specialized in furniture design and computer work.

Now, Yorgos the younger works side by side with his father, Vasilli, just as Vasilli worked side by side with his father, Yorgos. Their woodwork ranges from wall-to-wall cabinets made of birch plywood from Denmark to odd-shaped doors made from cedar hauled down from the mountain for a primitive stone building used as a base for sheepherding and orchard tending. Nikitas, the sheep-











CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT—
Yorgos, who trained at a cabinetmaker's school in Athens, operates the Rafael CNC panel saw.

New doors and windows for the refurbished and remodeled homes of Kyparissi.

While most of the tools and machines in Vasilli's shop would be familiar to woodworkers in the States, some others, such as this combination tablesaw/chopsaw, are more unusual.

Moulding head cutters and panelsaw blades fill a wall.

Standing against another wall is a vintage stroke sander, which still gets lots of use.

and goat herder, grape- and olive-grower, and roof tile man, wanted a strong old-fashioned door, and he got it.

The wood for that door came easily. To get his other wood, Vasilli has to order it from Alefsina, a port near Pireus, between four and five hours away, depending on the traffic. Alefsina has all kinds of lumber yards. They take the stock off boats and store it for builders. Vasilli shops around by phone, orders what he needs: pine imported from Sweden, iroko from Africa, and cherry, walnut and maple from the United States.

Big orders are delivered over the mountain to them; Vasilli and/or Yorgos get smaller orders in their truck. They make the long trip about once every two months. But he also has to take care of getting his other supplies and tools, making a trip every two weeks to Tripoli and Sparti to get nails, screws, sandpaper, varnish, paint, and hardware. These are working towns, relatively tourist-free. Hardware stores abound, and they are filled with everything you need to build something: fancy cabinet hardware from Italy and sturdy handtools from Germany and Japan. They are also packed with all the other necessities of village life: hoses, buckets, sheep bells, wheelbarrows, rope, ladders, paint brushes, cigarettes—all the things you need, all of the things you would find in a Home Depot, only more.

Sometimes he doesn't make the trip himself. Somebody from the village is always going, and special orders can be picked up and delivered by friends.









CLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT—
Yorgos Vasilliou hand planes a table base.

The hotel in Paralia (the waterfront part of the town of Kyparissi)is now owned by Vasilli, who also made these new doors for it.

The mermaids on the panels were hand-carved by Vasilli in the wee hours of the night, when he likes to do his quiet work.

Ostriches graze in Vasilli Vasilliou's front yard.

The shop also does traditional handwork with hand chisels for gifts and special orders of furniture, like on Nikita's door, and the furniture that Vasilli makes for his wife. He does this at three in the morning until about seven, so no one will bother him and look over his shoulder. "I don't want people to watch me and take my mind away."

He also makes traditional furniture for restored houses. Vasilli and Yorgos work all over the area, including nearby (about an hour-and-a-half drive over the mountains) Monovassia and Molais. He has done a lot of renovation work for Germans who have restored old stone Venetian houses in Monovassia. Germans own an inordinate number of houses in this historic site. About 30 or 40 years ago, a German tourist fell in love with the ruins of the village and he asked around to find out how he could buy a house to restore. The trouble was, they were ruins and, according to ill-kept records, no one owned them, so he could find no one to play the seller to his buyer. But, according to Greek law, the governor could make a proclamation determining ownership, and the party named could then sell the property. The governor named his cousin, who in turn sold the property to the German, split the take with his governor/cousin, and everyone, in the words of Melena Mercouri in *Never On A Sunday*, went to the seashore.

While Vasilli gets great pleasure from the handwork required in restorations in jobs like those in Monovassia, most of his output requires all the modern equipment of the cabinet trade.

For example, take edgebanding. For a long time he used a paper material that he had to iron onto the edge. The paper would eventually peel away, especially in houses that were only used in the summer. Not so today. He now has a Holz-Her edgebander that glues on veneer or PVC, trims it to size, and even bevels the edges for decoration. In addition to saving him endless hours of work, the German machine also creates a better product, much to Vasilli's satisfaction.

Also among his modern machinery is an SCM *L'Invincible*, an Italian moulding cutter and joint-maker, and a Rafael computerized tablesaw, if that is what you can call something this sophisticated. It compares to a tablesaw the way a Piper Cub compares to the Concorde. Vasilli (sometimes) or Yorgos (most of the time) punches the required dimensions into the machine's keyboard, and simply places a board or panel on the table that is about as big as four ping pong tables in a square, and air clamps come down and hold it in place at the right angles, and a sawblade rises in the table, like a shark fin in calm waters, and you can almost hear the theme song from *Jaws* as it comes down the table and trims the board's width left to right, and then another blade comes along back to front and cuts the board's length. A smaller scoring blade that cuts counter-clockwise adjusts independently for different materials. It is a genius machine.

He uses a huge pneumatic Baldoni clamping machine for gluing up doors and windows, saving countless hours of

work. Not to mention the standard tablesaws, jointers, and planers.

Unlike the ancient bandsaw, these massive machines are trucked in over several serious mountains. A mechanic comes along with the machines to set them up and dial them in. The machines are guaranteed, so if he has a rare problem that cannot be fixed by phone, a mechanic travels down to the village, no inconsiderable trip.

His shop features not only the latest machinery, it has a good dust collection system, which will soon be replaced with a newer, bigger, more terrific model. The cost of all of this is considerable. The Casadei checks in at about 8,500,000 drachmae, which sounds like a lot because it is: $23,000. The Holz-Her costs 18-1/2 million drachmae ($51,000).

Here's the kicker: The European Economic Council (EEC) helps out with about 50% support. Vasilli gets his funding thorugh a local project, Leader, that started in 1991; it is based in Astros, up the coast. It was designed to support local craftspeople with disappearing skills in "fragile rural areas," to use the phrase from their web page, and "…in approximately equal parts (it) incorporates five main sub-measures: Enterprise creation and development, environment and infrastructure; un/underemployed, education and community development." It is amazingly like the multitude of grants available in education for craftspeople and artisans in the States.

Greece needs EEC money because the European Community gives Greece roughly $4 billion a year, as much as net tourism and shipping together bring in. But the same hand that giveth taketh away. Not only are imports hit with a heavy tax, but the EEC, while providing funds for crucial projects like Vasilli's sophisticated tools and the new Athens subway, created an 18% Value Added Tax (VAT) that applies to basic supplies like wood as well—indeed, VAT goes all along the economic food chain.

Still, Vasilli is more than grateful. As he describes it: "The EEC, they look for guys like me who make barrels, caiques, and saddles for the donkeys. They found me and helped me."

But here is another story: Just as things got really prosperous, Vasilli and Sophia were in a horrible traffic accident. They were going to Sparti for supplies, wood, and to charge or replace a flat battery. On the main road in the late afternoon a car drifted into their lane and hit them head on.

Vasilli had the battery in the cab at Sophia's feet. To make room for her, he turned it long ways on the floor (parallel to the drive shaft), and the battery absorbed most of the shock on her side, but he was not so lucky. His legs were broken in sixteen different places. The driver had a couple of DUIs to his credit and a local history of careless driving habits, and, in an accident straight out of myths, a few months after nearly killing Vasilli and Sophia, his tractor with him aboard tipped over, killing him.

Vasilli was helicoptered out of the hospital in Sparti to Athens. Sophia called Yorgos, who was going to school there in Athens at the time, and told him about the accident, saying his father was going to the hospital there. In the confusion, she forgot to tell him which one. Yorgos had to go from hospital to hospital until he finally found the right one.

Vasilli recovered, and you can see a slight limp if you know to look for it. The wrecked truck sat in his yard for a long time as a reminder of the vagaries of life, but he has recently had it hauled away because "it makes me think too much about those things."

Besides the truck, alot of things sit in his yard amongst the olive trees: a pig, dozens of chickens, a few turkeys. Friends' boats, my car when I am not there, and two ostriches. That's right, ostriches! It was never quite clear where they come from and why they are here, but here they are. All of these look surprisingly at home.



Coming from a long line of woodworkers and seafarers, Vasilli tends to his fishing nets, with the assistance of his nephew. A unit of lumber is stacked in the yard outside the shop. Life is full.

At ten o'clock every morning, Vasilli goes to Ravatso's taverna for coffee and friendship. He mostly goes to meet the fishermen who come in around that time, finished with their day's work. He checks out where the fish are. They tell stories, gossip and joke, and then Vasilli goes back to work. Babala behind him, the Myrtou Sea in front. His life all around.

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